

ALLIES IN STEP PM Narendra Modi welcomes Russian president Vladimir Putin at Palam airport, New Delhi, Dec. 4

ANI

> **"PM Modi and I have laid out an ambitious plan for collaborating in forward-looking areas, especially high technology. AI, for example, which is transforming the world"**

Q. During Operation Sindoor, the weapons we had acquired from Russia proved to be crucial in India's victory. When can we expect the remaining S400 air defence systems that India has purchased? There is also talk of Russia offering S500s as well as its fifth generation fighter jet, Su-57. Are you going to push that on your visit?

A. If we delve into the substance, India stands out as one of our reliable and privileged partners in this area. We are not merely selling something to India, and India isn't merely buying something from us in the sphere of defence and security. No. It is a different level, a different quality of relations we have with India, and we value this. We see how India values this relationship too. Why? Allow me to emphasise again: we are not simply selling technology—we are sharing it, and it is a very rare thing to see in the sphere of military-technical cooperation. It speaks to the level of trust between the two countries and the level of trust between the two peoples, I would put it this way. We have a broad portfolio indeed, including naval construction, rocket and missile engineering, and aircraft engineering. You just mentioned the Su-57 aircraft. India operates several other Russian-made aircraft too. Moreover, the famous BrahMos missile—a joint venture between Russia and India—is manufactured primarily at Indian facilities. Therefore, Prime Minister Modi's 'Make in India' initiative should be implemented in this area too.

Q. Russia has been one of the biggest movers when it comes to nuclear facilities in India. Are we looking at important announcements on the nuclear front?

A. Yes, of course, we have some announcements to make. We are not "movers", we are producers of the world's most advanced and reliable equipment for nuclear power plants. The well-known facility and our joint project, the Kudankulam plant, is one of the leaders in this regard. Russia is probably the only country in the world today capable of building, and does build, small nuclear power plants. Such plants are already operational in Russia and these compact nuclear power modules can thus be deployed in isolated and hard-to-access locations.

Q. How do you think US president Donald Trump will react to all this?

A. You know, neither me nor Prime Minister Modi, despite certain external pressure we face, have ever—and I want to emphasise this—approached our collaboration as working against someone. President Trump has his own agenda, his own goals, whereas we focus on ours—not against anyone,